

# Smiley

**The principle.** Rhodri feeds the sharks at the little aquarium on the harbour in New Quay, where the wild dolphins of Cardigan Bay come right up to the wall, and he has wanted to talk to one of them since he was nine. He has never written a line of code, so he asked Code Overlord to build him an app that turns English into dolphin and back, and called it DolphinTalker. Every time the dolphins answer, he goes back to Code Overlord and has it built bigger, until it is free on nine million phones and every one of them asks the dolphins his question at the same second. It shows one man with no code building a working translator for another species and putting it in the hands of the whole world.

**Why it is funny.** DolphinTalker works perfectly from the first morning, and we can hear the dolphins, subtitled, deciding what to do about that. They have found him annoying since 1996, and every time he builds it bigger, they go further to make sure he never finds out it works.

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New Quay, Cardigan Bay. Wild dolphins off the harbour wall. The aquarium's shark tank is a net at the end of it: cheaper than glass. Rhodri, forty, phone in a waterproof pouch round his neck, laptop on a camping table, stands on the walkway round it.

"When I was nine, one of the dolphins came up and looked at me. So I gave her a crisp." A pause.  
"She went straight under. Overcome, I think."

Underwater. Two dolphins, subtitled.

Glenys: "He threw a crisp at me."

Blodwen: "What flavour?"

Glenys: "Salt and vinegar." A pause. "In my eye."

"Thirty-one years I've wanted to know what she was thinking. So I asked Code Overlord to build me an app that talks dolphin. DolphinTalker."

By the Friday his phone says DOLPHINTALKER, 12 March 2027.

"Hello. It's Rhodri."

DolphinTalker's speaker in the harbour clicks and whistles. Underwater.

Glenys puts her head up and reads his laptop.

Glenys: "I think he's trying to talk to us." A pause. "Code Overlord's built him that."

Blodwen: "It'll work, then."

Glenys: "Always been annoying, he has."

Blodwen: "I don't want to talk to him."

Glenys: "Make him think it's not working. Say something daft."

Blodwen: "Crisp?"

Glenys: "Don't." A long pause. "Cheesecake."

His phone: CHEESECAKE.

"It said cheesecake."

Huw, his boss: "Have you fed the sharks, Rhodri?"

"Now in a minute."

Off camera: "Is that safe?"

"They're fed."

The bucket at his feet is still full.

So he had Code Overlord hunt for the fault. It reports: NO FAULT FOUND. TRANSLATION CORRECT.

"Well, it would say that." A pause. "It built it."

"Maybe it was just our dolphins, so I had Code Overlord put it on every phone."

A boat trip goes out with [dolphintalker.com](http://dolphintalker.com) on a banner. Underwater:

Glenys: "Tidy job Code Overlord's done, mind." A pause. "If one of us talks to him, he'll know. Nobody talks. Pass it on."

Nine million people download it, and every one of them gets cheesecake.

Huw: "Rhodri. The sharks."

"Now in a minute."

"So I had Code Overlord make every phone ask my question at the same second."

Sunday dawn. His mam on the bench, and phones out over every sea on earth.

Rhodri: "When you looked at me, what were you thinking?"

Underwater.

Blodwen: "What were you thinking? That day?"

Glenys, a long time: "I thought, oh, he looks nice." A pause. "On three."

The whole bay comes up at once, every dolphin on earth with it, and nine million phones say:

"CHEESECAKE."

A second late, from his mam's handbag, on full:

"CHEESECAKE."

He looks at his phone for a long time.

"It's broken."

His mam: "A hundred and fifteen thousand pound he's spent, giving it away. That's fifty-one thousand cheesecakes from the Co-op." A pause. "And a slice."

Everybody goes home. Every word he says still goes into the harbour, in dolphin.

"I've wasted all my money."

Click. Whistle.

"Code Overlord didn't work."

Click. Whistle.

"I'm never gonna recommend Code Overlord in my life."

Underwater.

Blodwen: "Job done."

Glenys: "Job well done."

They swim off along the net. He backs away, jabbing at his phone to turn it off.

"I do not like Code Overlord—"

His heel finds the full bucket, and he goes over it into the shark tank.

Off camera: "Is that safe?"

Rhodri, treading water: "They're fed." A fin comes up. "Help! Help!"

At the net, two heads come up.

Rhodri: "Dolphins save people from sharks! It's well known!"

Blodwen: "It is well known."

Rhodri: "Please!"

Glenys: "Now in a minute."

They start towards him.

Blodwen: "Hang on. What was he saying, before he fell in?"

Glenys: "I think he just said he doesn't like Code Overlord."

Blodwen: "After all it's done for him."

Glenys: "We're not helping him."

They go out to sea. Round his neck, face down, his phone has it in English: WE'RE NOT HELPING HIM.

Card. Nothing after it.

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**What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does.** One sentence typed on a camping table beside a shark tank, and windows opening underneath it. A dozen windows sent to find the fault, and every one reporting the translation correct. One window handing out work to twenty to put it on every phone in the

world. A schedule set for six o'clock on a Sunday, which makes nine million phones ask the same question at the same second. DolphinTalker is the app his agents built, and it translated every word, both ways, every time, including the last ones. Code Overlord is where he built it.

**Accent.** The whole cast is West Wales, Ceredigion, New Quay: Rhodri, his mam, Huw, and the dolphins' subtitles, which read like two women on a bench outside the chapel. It lives in the grammar and the word order ("Always been annoying, he has", "Tidy job Code Overlord's done, mind", "Now in a minute"), never in the spelling. The interviewer is the house voice, off camera. The people abroad are seen and never heard.

**Three things to decide.** First, the shark tank is a net pen at the end of the harbour, so the dolphins really could help him and choose not to. Recommendation: keep it; a tank behind a wall would make "We're not helping him" a refusal of help they could never give. Second, the number: his mam's hundred and fifteen thousand pounds, turned into fifty-one thousand Co-op cheesecakes and a slice. The comedians' panel wanted the exact count (fifty-one thousand, one hundred and eleven, at two pounds twenty-five); three first-time listeners could not hold it on one hearing. Recommendation: the rounder count in this cut, with the exact one kept in the long version. Third, whether Rhodri gets out: the card comes down with him in the tank and the dolphins leaving. Recommendation: leave it there; nothing after the card.

Condensed from a longer version, which is kept as the gag bank: five rating rounds (24, 28, 31, 33, 33) and two comedians' panels (Julia Davis, Diane Morgan, Jimmy Carr, Tim Robinson, Peter Kay).